


FREE-SOURCE EDITION

The Health of UK High Streets

Regional footfall, local vacancy and the role of
vape shops, barbers and charity shops

NO PAID DATASETS · NO MEMBER-ONLY TABLES

Rebuilt September 2026 · All 12 UK nations and English regions

The Health of UK High Streets

Briefing for Rory — rebuilt September 2026

Evidence rule: every headline figure in this edition is available without buying a dataset or joining a trade body. Sources are ONS, councils, devolved governments, Open Data NI, free BID reports, public registers, open research, and freely published property-company notes.

Executive conclusion

UK high streets are **rebalancing rather than uniformly collapsing**. Savills, citing Green Street, reported GB high-street vacancy at **13.2% in Q1 2026**, down from 13.4% in Q4 2025; shopping-centre vacancy was higher at **16.9%**.^[1] The national improvement conceals severe local voids: Peterlee **40.8%**, Bishop Auckland **35.4%**, Hanley **30.4%**, Leicester **22.1%**, Elgin **20%**, Carmarthen **19%**, and Reading **18.6% of units** in their respective council studies.^{[2][3][4][5][6][7]}

The recurring evidence is stronger for **footfall** than for vacancy. Calculations from the free ONS monthly workbook show Q2 2026 town-and-city-centre footfall was below Q2 2025 in nine of the eleven published GB regions, while London rose 8.0% and Scotland rose 0.7%. Wales fell 9.1% and the West Midlands 8.5%.^[8] The series begins in July 2024, is not seasonally adjusted, excludes local residents from counts, and suppresses Northern Ireland; it should be read as a pulse, not a long-term league table.

Vape shops, barbers and charity shops are **not one “filler” category**:

- **Vape shops:** England’s open OS Points of Interest evidence shows an almost **1,200% rise from 2014 to 2024**, with twice the density in the North as the South and more than three times the provision in the most deprived areas.^[9] They occupy units, but youth access and illicit products make them an enforcement and public-health issue.
- **Barbers and beauty:** official business counts support growth in the combined hair, barber, nail and beauty economy, but there is no free UK high-street barber census. Council audits show these businesses can dominate retail-service space: Elgin recorded **20 hairdresser/barber units** in 2025.^[5]
- **Charity shops:** the Charity Retail Association’s public page records **9,900+ UK shops, 24,900+ FTE staff, 223,500+ volunteers and £300m+ profit to parent charities in 2024/25**.^[10] They provide social value and occupied frontage, but are not proof of strong commercial demand.

Practical judgement: vacancy going down is positive, but a healthy centre also needs essential services, a diverse use mix, repeat footfall, viable local businesses and effective enforcement. If pharmacies and banks disappear while vape and takeaway uses cluster, occupancy may improve while health worsens.

1. What this free evidence can measure

Question	Best free source	Cadence	Main limitation
Are visits rising?	ONS UK retail footfall (BT Active Intelligence)	Weekly/monthly	From July 2024; not seasonally adjusted; NI suppressed
Is GB vacancy improving?	Savills/Knight Frank public notes citing Green Street	Quarterly headline when published	GB headline, not a free regional table
Which named towns have empty units?	Council health checks and retail studies	Six-monthly to annual, irregular	Boundaries and methods differ
What is happening in NI?	LPS Open Data NI	Quarterly	All non-domestic property, not shop-only
How are high-street jobs changing?	ONS BRES high-street dataset	Periodic/annual source data	Employment, not occupancy
How is the use mix changing?	Council audits, CRA public stats, HEN/OS POI, Scotland NVP register	Mixed	Categories and geographies are incompatible
Where does resident spending leak?	ONS/Visa postal-district flow data	Latest published data only to Q3 2023	Not a dependable quarterly publication

There is **no free, comparable quarterly shop-vacancy rate for every UK region or town**, and no free live catchment-spend series. This report therefore separates:

1. a recurring national and regional **footfall pulse**;
2. a recurring **GB property headline**;
3. a **town evidence ledger** updated whenever councils publish;
4. sector evidence updated at its natural cadence.

2. Quarterly pulse: footfall and vacancy

2.1 Town-and-city-centre footfall

The table is calculated from the ONS workbook published 17 September 2026. It compares the average monthly index for April–June 2026 with April–June 2025. The index is based on BT Active Intelligence and has 2023 average = 100.[8]

Nation / English region	Q2 2026 vs Q2 2025
London	+8.0%
Scotland	+0.7%
East of England	−4.1%
North West	−4.2%
North East	−5.1%
South East	−5.3%
South West	−5.6%
East Midlands	−5.9%
Yorkshire and the Humber	−6.6%
West Midlands	−8.5%
Wales	−9.1%
Northern Ireland	Not published / suppressed

This is a stronger quarterly comparison than using one month, but it is still **not seasonally adjusted**. August 2026 had already moved in a different direction: London was 13.8% above August 2025, Scotland 2.9% higher, while the North East and Yorkshire and the Humber were both 4.6% lower. Weather, holidays and calendar composition matter.

2.2 GB property headline

Savills’ free Q1 2026 note, using Green Street vacancy data, reported:[1]

- GB high-street vacancy **13.2%**, down from 13.4% in Q4 2025;
- shopping-centre vacancy **16.9%**, up from 16.3% in Q4 2025;
- service, food and beverage, health and wellbeing, and convenience operators continuing to absorb space.

This is the best free quarterly national benchmark found, but the underlying regional and town tables are not open. It must not be used to infer that every region improved.

2.3 Northern Ireland quarterly property pulse

The live LPS CSV reports **all non-domestic rated properties**, not high-street shops.[11]

Geography	31 Mar 2026	30 Jun 2026
Northern Ireland	15.8%	15.3%
Belfast	20.6%	19.5%
Fermanagh and Omagh	—	16.2%
Newry, Mourne and Down	15.8%	15.6%
Derry City and Strabane	—	15.0%
Lisburn and Castlereagh	—	11.6%

The June improvement is useful as a property-market pulse. It is not comparable with council walk-over shop-vacancy surveys or the GB high-street rate.

3. Region-by-region free evidence

North East England

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **5.1% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Durham County Council's 2025 surveys, reported by the BBC, put town-centre vacancy at **19.1% overall**. Peterlee was **40.8%**, Bishop Auckland **35.4%**, Newton Aycliffe 26.0%, while Seaham was 8.4% and Crook 8.8%.^[2] Durham City was 11.7%. This is one of the clearest demonstrations that variation inside a region is greater than any regional average suggests.

Mix: Health Equity North reports North East takeaways up 35% from 2014 to 2024, banks down 30%, pharmacies down 16% and public toilets down 32%.^[9] North East Trading Standards found 44% of a small 32-retailer test-purchase sample sold vapes to an underage volunteer and seized 1.4 tonnes of illegal disposable products in 2022 operations.^[12]

Conclusion: priority is not simply filling units; it is restoring essential amenities and enforcement capacity in the weakest towns.

North West England

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **4.2% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Open local evidence: Manchester BID's free reports show how a managed core can monitor monthly visitors, but its counters cover the BID footprint, not the region.^[13] Blackpool, Preston, Blackburn and Bolton appear among the higher-density vape localities in open reporting of the HEN/OS study.^[14]

Chain market: PwC's freely published 2024 regional release recorded **956 multiple-store openings and 1,311 closures**, net –355, for the North West. It covers chains with five or more outlets and all retail locations, not independents or high streets alone.^[15]

Conclusion: Manchester's managed centre and event economy should not be treated as a proxy for coastal Lancashire or district centres. A current free regional vacancy rate is unavailable.

Yorkshire and the Humber

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **6.6% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Open local evidence: Leeds' authority monitoring and Visit Leeds reporting show a strong regional centre, while Bradford's own 2023/24 monitoring report says updated centre assessments were still pending.^[16] Claims that Bradford leaks spend to Leeds and Sheffield to Meadowhall remain useful structural explanations from Centre for Cities, but its July 2025 city vacancy estimates are one-off and partly modelled, so they are not current KPIs.^[17]

Chain market: PwC recorded **857 openings and 1,182 closures** among multiples in 2024, net –325.^[15]

Conclusion: monitor Leeds and Sheffield footfall, but use fresh council surveys—not modelled city rankings—for vacancy decisions.

East Midlands

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **5.9% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Nottingham's July 2024 health check recorded **21.1% vacant units**, or 16.3% excluding Broadmarsh redevelopment units.^[18] Leicester's study recorded **22.1% of units vacant** and 23.1% of comparison floorspace.^[4] Derby recorded **18.2% of outlets vacant** and annual footfall above 60 million in 2024, still below 65.5 million in 2019.^[19] Newark recorded 12.63% vacancy in 2024.^[20]

Conclusion: redevelopment voids must be separated from market vacancy. Nottingham shows how one large scheme can distort a city headline.

West Midlands

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **8.5% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**, the weakest English-region change in the quarter.^[8]

Council evidence: Hanley's July 2025 health check recorded **154 vacant outlets, 30.4% of units and 27.6% of floorspace**.^[3] Wolverhampton recorded **25.4% of outlets vacant** in 2023/24 and Walsall's primary shopping area 25.3%; the Black Country study cautions that regeneration and large closed units inflate some totals.^[21] Coventry's January 2024 survey recorded 16.0% vacancy across its prime area, but 46.6% in City Centre South during redevelopment.^[22]

Mix: Much Wenlock's 2024 council survey recorded only **7% vacancy**, three hair/beauty businesses and one charity shop—an important small-town contrast.^[23]

Conclusion: Hanley and Black Country cores require structural reduction and reuse of retail space; a single West Midlands average would hide healthier centres.

East of England

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **4.1% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Norwich's 2025 monitor recorded **15.1% vacant town-centre units** and 14.4% vacant floorspace when all town-centre uses were included.^[24] Ipswich's 2024/25 survey recorded **19.0% vacant units** across the central shopping area.^[25] Grays' October 2024 health check recorded 13.4% vacancy in its core shopping area.^[26]

Conclusion: the region contains strong knowledge-economy centres and stressed traditional cores. Free council data supports town comparison, not a single regional vacancy figure.

London

Quarterly pulse: London town-and-city-centre footfall was **8.0% higher in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Wandsworth's 2025 survey covered about 2,500 properties. Town-centre vacancy fell from 8.1% to **7.9%**; Wandsworth town centre fell from 15% to 13%, while Putney rose from 11% to 12%.^[27]

Central activity: TfL reported central-London pedestrian flows in July–September 2024 at about 90% of 2019.^[28] Outer and local high streets often benefit more from resident demand than commuter-dependent central pitches.

Conclusion: London's footfall recovery is real in the ONS series, but borough and pitch differences remain substantial.

South East England

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **5.3% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Reading's health check recorded **131 vacant outlets, 18.6% of units, and 27.1% of floorspace** in May 2024, with large-format voids central to the result.^[7] Winchester's 2024 town-centre study appendices show active requirements from charity retailers, illustrating continued demand for some secondary units.^[29]

Open property evidence: free agent reports describe tight prime South East markets, but their local rates use different portfolios and definitions. They should not be compared directly with Reading's Goad survey.

Conclusion: affluent catchment income does not prevent oversupply or large-unit obsolescence.

South West England

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **5.6% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Mid Devon's health checks recorded Tiverton vacancy at about **8.4%** in 2022/23 and map service uses, including barbers, in centres such as Crediton.^[30] Bath and North East Somerset's free Vacant Units Action Project documents meanwhile uses and activation rather than a uniform vacancy series.^[31]

Conclusion: tourism and seasonality make quarter-on-quarter comparisons risky; use year-on-year footfall and local audits together.

Wales

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **9.1% lower in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

National evidence: Welsh Government's 2025 *Filling the gaps* report says about **one in six shops** is empty and persistent vacancy was **7.7% in 2023**; these figures are contextual, not a live quarterly index.^[32]

Council evidence: Cardiff's evidence recorded **17.4% vacancy** in its central shopping area in Q4 2024, with district/local centres around 9% on average.^[33] Carmarthen recorded **19% vacancy** in March 2024.^[6] Monmouthshire's 2024 survey recorded Abergavenny at **9.4%** and Caldicot's central shopping area at 9%.^[34]

Conclusion: Wales needs a coordinated open town-centre monitoring standard. Current evidence is strong locally but not synchronised nationally.

Scotland

Quarterly pulse: town-and-city-centre footfall was **0.7% higher in Q2 2026 than Q2 2025**.^[8]

Council evidence: Moray's summer 2025 survey recorded **50 vacant Elgin units (20%)**, up from 40 units (16%) in 2023; the closed St Giles Centre accounted for 26 vacancies. Forres had only seven vacant units, down more than 60% from 2023.^[5] Dumfries and Galloway's 2023 health checks recorded a 15% regional-town average and 18% in Dumfries, using its own centre boundaries.^[35]

Nicotine retail: Scotland's mandatory register provides a free outlet base. A Scottish Government May 2026 impact assessment recorded **11,586 active registrations:** 3,100 tobacco-only, 6,781 tobacco-and-vape, and 1,705 vape-only.[36] These are registered outlets, including convenience and supermarkets—not specialist high-street vape shops.

Conclusion: combine ONS footfall, council health checks and the NVP register; do not substitute the vacant-and-derelict-land survey for shop vacancy.

Northern Ireland

Quarterly property pulse: NI non-domestic vacancy fell from **15.8% in March 2026 to 15.3% in June**; Belfast fell from 20.6% to 19.5%.[11]

Town evidence: Derry/Londonderry's 2021 council study recorded **62 vacant units out of 450 (13.7%)** and 12 charity shops.[37] Newtownards' 2025 study found **21.3% commercial vacancy across the study area but only 5.2% on the High Street core**, illustrating a strong core-fringe split.[38]

Conclusion: LPS is the UK's best free quarterly vacancy dataset, but its broad property definition means it must be paired with less frequent town-centre walkovers.

4. Sector contribution and limitations

Vape shops

Contribution: specialist retailers and convenience outlets pay rent, support some employment and can advise adult smokers switching away from cigarettes.

Evidence of risk: HEN/OS records the large and unequal rise in England.[9] ASH's 2024 GB youth survey found **48% of current 11–17-year-old vapers cited shops as a source** and 55% of young people aware of vaping had seen promotion in shops.[39] Trading Standards evidence shows underage sales and illegal products remain material.[12]

Assessment: count vape units separately from convenience stores; record proximity to schools and enforcement outcomes. Do not count their presence as an unqualified regeneration success.

Barbers and personal services

Contribution: they are labour-intensive, difficult to move online, create repeat visits and use small units.

Evidence boundary: ONS SIC 96.02 counts hairdressing and beauty enterprises, not barbers alone and not high-street frontage.[40] CSJ's open analysis of official business counts reports the combined barber, nail and beauty category up 22% since 2016, but it should not be presented as a barber-only statistic.[41] Elgin's 20 units demonstrate local importance.[5]

Assessment: use council retail-service counts locally. Do not claim a national "barber boom" from proprietary unit data.

Charity shops

Contribution: CRA's public totals demonstrate employment, volunteering, reuse, affordable goods and more than £300m returned to parent charities in 2024/25.[10]

Nuance: HEN's England POI series found charity-shop provision per 10,000 people fell **21% from 2014 to 2024**, so the story is not endless expansion.[9] Rates relief helps occupy marginal units but means an occupied charity unit does not necessarily indicate strong commercial rental demand.

Assessment: treat charity retail as social infrastructure and an occupier, while separately tracking commercial demand.

5. Free quarterly monitoring template

Every quarter

1. Download the latest **ONS UK retail footfall XLSX**.
2. Average the three monthly index values in the quarter and compare with the same quarter a year earlier.
3. Report GB regions for **town and city centres**, district/local centres and retail parks separately.
4. Download the latest **LPS NI non-domestic vacancy CSV**.
5. Check for a new free **Savills, Knight Frank or Green Street property note**.
6. Search each priority council for a new health check, retail survey or authority monitoring report.
7. Update CRA public statistics, HEN/ASH evidence or enforcement figures only when a new open release appears.

Minimum dashboard fields

Field	Required note
Period	Survey month/quarter and publication date
Geography	Exact town-centre, BID or council boundary
Unit vacancy	Vacant units / surveyed units
Floorspace vacancy	Record separately from unit vacancy
Regeneration voids	Exclude or show a second rate
Footfall	Index/source; YoY preferred
Mix	Comparison, convenience, food, service, charity, vape, barber, vacant
Essential amenities	Bank, pharmacy, supermarket, public toilet
Enforcement	Vape test purchases, seizures, closure orders
Source quality	Official/council, open property note, BID, or one-off model

Priority free-source places

- **Distress cases:** Peterlee, Bishop Auckland, Hanley, Leicester, Elgin, Carmarthen, Reading.
- **Contrasts:** Seaham/Crook within County Durham; Forres vs Elgin; Wandsworth vs Putney; Cardiff centre vs district centres; Newtownards core vs fringe.
- **Structural competition:** Bradford/Leeds, Sheffield/Meadowhall and Bristol/Cribbs may remain qualitative until a current open spend-flow dataset appears.

6. Limitations

- There is no free quarterly shop-vacancy series for all UK regions.
- ONS footfall starts in July 2024 and is not seasonally adjusted.
- NI LPS covers all non-domestic rated property, not retail or high-street units alone.
- Council surveys use different boundaries, dates and definitions.
- Property-company headline vacancy is national and based on proprietary underlying data, although the headline note is free.
- Centre for Cities 2025 vacancy estimates are one-off and partly modelled; they are context, not monitoring.
- Vape, barber and charity datasets use incompatible classifications and must not be merged into a “filler index”.
- Catchment spending cannot be updated quarterly from free published data.

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